By evening, seeing his allies sinking into ever greater despondency, Shah Shuja tried to cheer up the depressed officers by proposing to throw a dinner. The response was glum. How could a dinner be thrown, replied the officers, when they had left their dress uniforms in the cantonment?[37] Even as Kabul burned, and with their position weakening by the minute, the British were determined that proper regimental etiquette should be observed to the end.

On the morning of 3 November, Eldred Pottinger was becoming nervous. With only one hundred troops, he was stationed in a small fortified enclosure – actually a converted caravanserai – at Laghmani, on a hilltop sixty miles north of Kabul and a short distance above the British barracks in Charikar, where the administration for Kohistan was housed. Now ever larger numbers of heavily armed Kohistanis were gathering around his tower house. Ostensibly the tribesmen were there to reconcile Pottinger's administration with some disaffected chiefs from the Nijrao district who had been driven into rebellion in 1840, and who had suffered badly in Sale's punitive expeditions that autumn; but Pottinger had a strong sense that something was amiss. 'I grew greatly alarmed at their increasing numbers,' he wrote later,

> and at their refusal to attack the Castles of the [insurgent] Chiefs who composed [the Kohistan rebel leader] Mir Masjidi's army. This feeling led to my taking sundry precautions for the security of my position against surprise. However as it appeared impolitic to shew any suspicion I was confined to half measures . . . On the 3rd the increase of armed men round my residence was most alarmingly thick and induced me to man the towers [of the fort]. In the morning the Chiefs who brought the Nijraoees were very anxious that I should receive their friends; and those Nijraoees who had come previously demanded presents and were indignant at not getting them. I sent several messages to these latter that if they would perform the services I had pointed out, I would not only give them presents, but procure for them dresses of honour from the King.

Pottinger's assistant, Lieutenant Charles Rattray,[z] then went to greet the new arrivals who were sitting in the adjoining stubble field, about thirty yards distant. According to the account of the Gurkha havildar [NCO] Moti Ram, 'Mr Rattray, who commanded one of the Affghan corps, was lured out to look, he said, at some new recruits which he had brought with him for service. They were mounted men. As Lt Rattray was examining them drawn